its hold on the Vokkaligas with both the Congress and BJP doubling down on efforts to woo them—the Congress via its state president D.K. Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga himself, and a CM aspirant from his party. Traditionally, the contest in the southern Karnataka districts has been between the JD(S) and Congress. But the BJP, mindful of the fact that the Old Mysuru region remains the only gap in its otherwise growing footprint in the state, is deploying a slew of tactics to turn it into a triangular fight—CM Basavaraj Bommai's move in late March to increase the OBC reservation for Vokkaligas and Lingayats (the state's other large caste group) being the latest salvo in that direction. Earlier, the PM had unveiled a 108 ft statue of Kempegowda, the 16th-century founder of Bengaluru and a community icon, and in December, Shah was in Mandya, the heartland of Vokkaliga politics, striking an aggressive stance against the JD(S), which had swept the district in the previous election.

But even while trying to corner the JD(S), both parties are wary about pushing the Vokkaliga community closer to the regional outfit. Such an outcome was evident in the 2018 election when all but six of the 37 seats that the JD(S) won came from the Old Mysuru region due to a Vokkaliga consolidation against the Congress—the tone of the campaign by former CM Siddaramaiah against his one-time mentor Gowda being a key reason for this turn of events. "Its identity alternates between a family-centric party and a caste-based party," says political commentator Prof. A. Narayana, who teaches public policy at Azim Premji University in Bengaluru. Hence, the following year, in 2019, Gowda's grandson Nikhil lost the Lok Sabha poll from Mandya despite his party holding all seven assembly seats in the district—the voters' sympathy went with the recently-widowed former actress and Independent candidate Sumalatha Ambareesh. This time, in the absence of any factors to evoke such strong sentiments, Old Mysuru will see a closer fight between the JD(S) and Congress, he thinks.

At the Mysuru rally, Gowda, reading out from a prepared speech, reminded people that he has worked for all sections of society—women, Dalits and Muslims—even though his tenure at the helm, as Karnataka CM and Prime Minister, were short-lived. Incidentally, Kumaraswamy's two terms as CM lasted only 20 and 14 months. That emotional appeal is also the main plank of the JD(S) campaign as it pleads for a clear majority for itself. "I'm sure you won't give me less than 50 seats. But I want a five-year government," Kumaraswamy implores the gathering. Unlike its bigger rivals, the Pancharathna Yatra has mostly relied on roadshows through small towns and villages rather than big rallies. Its five-point agenda includes programmes for health, education, employment, agriculture and housing. Partymen point out to the crowds that have waited up for Kumaraswamy to arrive at these meetings, often as late as midnight, as proof that the core supporter base of the JD(S) is intact. "We are also wonder-struck with the response," says JD(S) legislator K.A. Thippeswamy. The Yatra typically avoids taluk headquarters, preferring face-to-face interactions in the village clusters. The focus, he says, is on those assembly seats that the party lost by a close margin.

THE JD(S) FACES THE CHALLENGE OF RETAINING ITS HOLD ON THE VOKKALIGAS WITH BOTH THE CONGRESS AND BJP DOUBLING DOWN ON EFFORTS TO WOO THE COMMUNITY

In 2018, the JD(S) was the runner-up in six seats where the winning margins were below 5,000 and in about 13 seats where they were between 5,000 and 13,000.

Over the years, however, the JD(S) has been unable to stanch a steady exodus of leaders from its fold, beginning 2008, following Kumaraswamy's botched attempt to share power with the BJP. While the latter benefitted from a sympathy wave that helped it to come to power in Karnataka that year, the support base of the JD(S) gradually shrunk when even the Muslims started drifting to the Congress. Among the leaders who have left recently are sitting MLAs like S.R. Srinivas of Gubbi and K. Srinivas Gowda of Kolar, who were expelled last year for cross-voting in the Rajya Sabha election, and Arsikere legislator K.M. Shivalinge Gowda and Arkalgud MLA A.T. Ramaswamy, who quit last week to join the Congress and BJP, respectively. While the outgo has impacted the party, a JD(S) partyman claims it has no dearth of fresh faces to defend these seats. Besides, with the old Janata Dal hand C.M. Ibrahim as its state president, and Kumaraswamy's stand against right-wing campaigns over the past year on issues like hijab, halal meat and the boycott of Muslim traders, the JD(S) hopes to woo the Muslims back. The party, says Narayana, is often written off from poll to poll and its survival is called into question. "That hasn't happened and I don't think it will. It's a simple function of demand and supply," he says. Hence, the JD(S) over the past three elections has managed to pick up stray seats even in some northern districts where it doesn't have much of a presence.

Yet, its family-heavy structure means the JD(S) also has its hands full. With the tussle between Bhavani and Kumaraswamy over the Hassan ticket raging on—the latter apparently favours local party worker H.P. Swaroop over his sister-in-law—partymen say that Deve Gowda will have to inevitably step in. The party patriarch, his health improving, has also been meeting local leaders from the districts of late. For the JD(S), the chance to once again play kingmaker hinges on keeping its flock safe. ■